

THE REGISTRY

The HKEYs Demystified

The Windows registry is organised in the following way.

HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT:

Holds all file types and their associations

HKEY_CURRENT_USER:

Holds the settings for the user that's currently logged in

HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE:

Holds your computer's configuration information—both hardware and software

HKEY_USERS:

Holds the settings of all user accounts on your PC

Kill Apps Faster—I

If you're the impatient type and can't be troubled with the wait while Windows shuts down errant applications, there are two ways out for you—either make Windows shut down hung processes automatically, or reduce the time that Windows waits for before killing it.

To shut down applications automatically, open the registry editor (Start > Run, type "regedit" and press [Enter]), and navigate to `HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Control Panel\Desktop`. In the right hand pane, double-click "AutoEndTasks" and change the Value Data to 1 to enable automatic app kills. To disable the feature, change the Value Data back to "0".

Note: Keep in mind that if you want to apply this tweak—Windows might end up killing critical services before they have time to recover themselves, increasing the possibility of a system crash.

Kill Apps Faster—II

The second option is to reduce the time Windows waits for before showing you the "End Program" dialog box. Follow the instructions above to get to `HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Control Panel\Desktop` and double-click on "HungAppTimeout" and change the value data to the time (in milliseconds) you're willing to wait for an

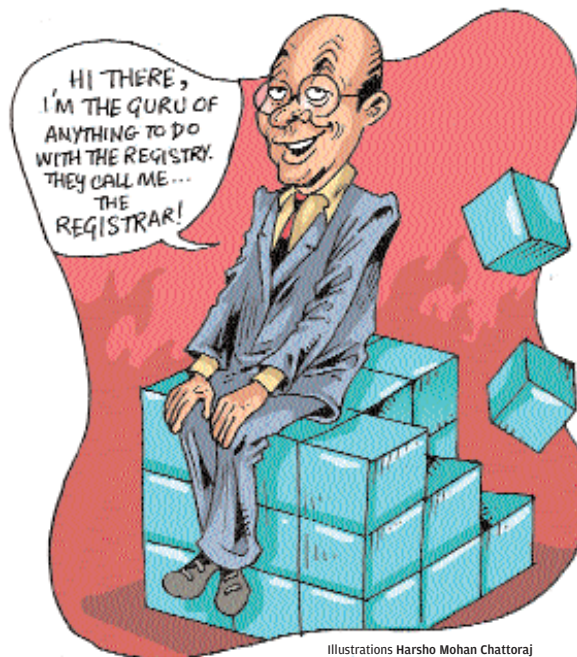


Tips & Tricks

SECRETS THAT KEEP YOU AHEAD IN THE RACE

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WINDOWS XP REGISTRY HACKS II



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unresponsive application. If you find applications that take too long to close when Windows is shutting down, you can also set the time that Windows will wait for before killing it. You'll find this value under "WaitToKillAppTimeout" in the same pane.

Kill Apps Faster—III

If you want to change the time that Windows waits before killing a system

service when shutting down, navigate to `HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SYSTEM\CurrentControlSet\Control` and double-click on "WaitToKillServiceTimeout" and enter a more acceptable value than the default 20000 milliseconds.

Save Your Tweaks

If you're a compulsive registry tweaker and like to switch between different settings often (like showing

and hiding the Administrator as above), you can save yourself some time and considerable inconvenience by using this simple method. Navigate to the key whose value you're changing. Go to **File > Export** and choose a save location and name for the exported registry file (extension: .reg). Open this file in Notepad. You will see "Windows Registry Editor Version 5.00" at the top, followed by the path to the key you just exported ("[HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run]" for example). Leave these two lines alone, and delete everything but the value you want to keep. For example, in the "Kill Apps Faster—III" tip, all you need would be the "WaitToKillServiceTimeout" key—the rest can be removed. Save as many copies as needed with different values for the key. For example, we saved one file called showadmin.reg with "Administrator" as 1, and another called hideadmin.reg with the value as 0. To change the settings, just double-click these .reg files. No more running into Regedit all the time!

Now that you've saved tweaks in different files, you can also share them with friends! Just make sure that they're not too application or user-specific. The safest option would be to share tweaks that apply to Windows directly.

A Background Image For Explorer Toolbars

To display a background bitmap for Windows Explorer toolbars, navigate to `HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Internet Explorer\Toolbar` and create a new String value by right-clicking in the right hand pane and selecting **New > String**. Call it "BackBitmapShell". Double-click on it and enter the path of the image you want to use as a background. The image must be in the .bmp format.